

# English

**Year 4**

Cambridge Early Years

Student Manual

---



[[MARK-Title-END]]

# English · Year 4

*Student Book · The Writing Table · Ages 8-9*

**Read carefully. Write clearly. Share the page.**

# About this book

English

*Year 4 · Student Book*

*The Writing Table*

Ages 8-9 · Cambridge pathway · Prime School

Spine sentence: **Read carefully. Write clearly. Share the page.**

At a warm wooden desk, a fox in a coat and a rabbit in a cardigan share ink, brushes and a stack of story pages. This book is that desk for you: a place to read carefully, write clearly, and share the page with someone who listens.

---

## Imprint

First edition, 2026.

Published by Prime Books, the publishing imprint of Prime School, [www.primeschool.pt](http://www.primeschool.pt)

(c) Prime School 2026. All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means without the prior written permission of the publisher, except for fair dealing for the purposes of research, private study or review, as permitted under copyright law.

An independent publication. This book is an original work produced by Prime School for use within its own programmes of study. It is not affiliated with, licensed by, endorsed by or otherwise approved by Collins, HarperCollins, Cambridge University Press, Cambridge Assessment International Education, or any examination body. References to curriculum frameworks represent the interpretation of the authors.

Original content. All teaching text, model extracts, worked examples, diagrams and illustrations planned for this edition are original to Prime School, unless a source is named in Sources and references.

Trademark acknowledgements. All trademarks are the property of their respective owners and are used for identification only.

British English edition.

Printed in Portugal on paper from responsibly managed forests.

# Contents

What is in this book. Page numbers match this PDF.

|                                   |    |
|-----------------------------------|----|
| Welcome to The Writing Table      | 6  |
| How to use this book              | 8  |
| Getting set up                    | 9  |
| Unit 1 · Story openings           | 11 |
| Unit 2 · Characters who speak     | 29 |
| Unit 3 · Poems and word music     | 41 |
| Unit 4 · Finding things out       | 53 |
| Unit 5 · Traditional tales        | 65 |
| Unit 6 · Reports and real writing | 77 |
| Word list                         | 89 |
| Sources and references            | 93 |
| For teachers                      | 94 |

# Welcome to The Writing Table

Welcome.

This book is about the craft of English: how stories start, how people speak on the page, how poems sound, how facts are found, how old tales travel, and how reports tell the truth clearly.

You will **read** model texts written for this book. You will **talk** about them with a partner. You will **write** openings, dialogue, poems, explanations, retellings and reports. You will **listen** so that other people's ideas improve your own.

At The Writing Table nobody needs perfect work on the first try. Careful work matters more. Read the page twice if you need to. Change a word if a better one arrives. Share your draft with a partner and listen to their draft in return.

When you finish a unit, you will have something real to show: a first page of a story, two voices talking, a poem to perform, an explanation someone can follow, a tale for a younger class, or a report from your school week.

Open your notebook. Sharpen your pencil. The desk is ready.

## Who you will meet

This book does not use speaking mascots. The cover shows tools of the craft. You will meet them again as small motifs on unit openers and panels:

| Motif                       | What it stands for              |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Quill and pen               | careful writing                 |
| Inkwell                     | ideas ready to use              |
| Watercolour tin             | pictures that support words     |
| Open sketchbook             | drafting and trying again       |
| Leaf and plant              | growing ideas, poems and nature |
| Wooden desk                 | a calm place to work            |
| Stack of illustrated sheets | finished work you can share     |

When you see a motif, it is a quiet reminder of the unit's mood, not a character who talks for you. **You** are the writer at the table.

# How to use this book

Every topic uses the same furniture, so you always know what to do.

| Panel                         | What you do                                                   |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>In this unit, you will</b> | Read the goals. Tick them at the end if you can.              |
| <b>Switch on</b>              | A question from life. Talk first. There is no wrong answer.   |
| <b>Here is how it works</b>   | Short teaching. Read with your teacher. Look at the extract.  |
| <b>Watch me work one out</b>  | One example done slowly. Follow each step.                    |
| <b>Your turn</b>              | Numbered practice. Write in your notebook. Leave space.       |
| <b>Go a little further</b>    | Stretch work when you finish early.                           |
| <b>Key words</b>              | Words to keep. Say them aloud. Copy them into your word book. |
| <b>What we learned</b>        | Self-check and unit words.                                    |
| <b>Along the way</b>          | The unit project: something to make, write or perform.        |

## Reading the page

- Take your time with pictures and extracts. They are part of the teaching.
- When you see a new word, read the whole sentence again.
- In talking time, listen as carefully as you speak.
- Write on the lines in your notebook, not only in your head.

## Working with a partner

1. One person speaks. The other listens without interrupting.
2. Swap.
3. Write one idea you borrowed from your partner.

# Getting set up

You do not need much:

- a pencil and a rubber
- coloured pencils or crayons
- a notebook with space to draft
- someone to talk with (a partner, a teacher, a grown-up at home)

## Your toolkit

- **Your eyes**, for looking carefully at extracts and pictures
- **Your voice**, for reading aloud and sharing ideas
- **Your ears**, for listening to other writers
- **Your hand**, for drafting, editing and writing a fair copy

## A little warm-up before Unit 1

Answer in your notebook:

1. What is one story you love, and why?
2. What would you most like to get better at in English this year?
3. Who could help you if you get stuck on a word?

When you can answer these, you are ready to begin.





UNIT 1

# 1

## Story openings

How stories catch a reader, and how to write a first page of your own

### © IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- ✓ Name the four building blocks of a story: character, want, setting, problem.
- ✓ Spot openings that pull a reader in, and say why they work.
- ✓ Build clear settings with when, where and the senses.
- ✓ Plan before you write, then draft an original opening.
- ✓ Finish a first-page story project you can share.

# Unit 1 • Story openings

*How stories catch a reader, and how to write a first page of your own*

Signal colour: fox #AD7241 (from the cover fur). Opener art: IMAGES/u1\_opener.png .

## 🕒 IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- Name the parts that make a story work: **character, want, setting, problem.**
- Spot openings that pull a reader in, and explain why they work.
- Build clear settings with **when, where** and the **senses.**
- Plan and write the opening of an original story.
- Finish a first-page project you can share at The Writing Table.

## ✦ LET US START

Think of a story you love (a book, a film, a family tale). Tell a partner:

- who the main character is, and what they want
- where and when the story happens
- the moment when something goes wrong

Listen carefully. Whose problem made you most want to know what happens next?

# What makes a story work

## ● SWITCH ON

With a partner, name a story you both know. Can you agree on:

1. the main character
2. what they want
3. where it happens
4. the first big problem

If you disagree, that is useful: it means the story has more than one way in.

## ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

Most stories that feel satisfying share four building blocks:

1. **Character**: who the story is about (a person, animal or group).
2. **Want**: what the character hopes for, needs or tries to do.
3. **Setting**: where and when the story happens.
4. **Problem**: the trouble that stops the want from being easy.

If any block is missing, the story feels thin.

- A character with no **want** drifts.
- A want with no **problem** is over too soon.
- A problem with no **setting** floats in empty air.

When you talk about stories, use these four words. They help you plan writing and help you listen as a reader.

At The Writing Table we do not only say "I liked it." We say *what worked* and *which block did the work*.

“ EXTRACT • ‘THE EMPTY JAR’

Ina stood on a chair in her grandmother's kitchen in Coimbra. The top shelf held one glass jar with a red lid. Inside, three dried orange peels rattled when she shook it.

"The recipe is gone," Ina whispered. "I only wanted to bake the winter cake."

Outside, the Mondego was grey with rain. The kitchen clock said 16:20. Ina put the jar down carefully. She would have to find the recipe another way.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Name the four building blocks in the extract.

| Block     | Evidence from the extract                   |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------|
| Character | Ina (grandmother is mentioned)              |
| Want      | to bake the winter cake                     |
| Setting   | grandmother's kitchen, Coimbra; rain; 16:20 |
| Problem   | the recipe is gone; only orange peels left  |

**Check it a different way:** Cover the extract. Retell the story in **one sentence** that uses all four words: character, want, setting, problem.

Example shape (do not copy word for word): *Ina, in a rainy Coimbra kitchen at 16:20, wants to bake a winter cake, but the recipe is missing.*

📖 READING TIP

When you meet a new word, read the whole sentence again. The words around it usually give you a clue about what it means.

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Copy the four building blocks into your notebook. Beside each, write a short definition in your own words.
2. In the extract, copy one sentence that shows the **setting**. Underline the time and the place.
3. Write the **problem** in exactly one sentence of your own (do not copy a whole line).
4. Invent a new character who walks into the same kitchen. Give them a **want** that is different from Ina's. Write two sentences.
5. With a partner, summarise a story you both know in four bullet points only (character, want, setting, problem).
6. Stretch: change only the **setting** of 'The empty jar' (new place, new time) and rewrite the first three sentences so the new setting feels true.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write a five-sentence micro-story set in Portugal that uses all four blocks. Circle the problem sentence in a coloured pencil. Read it to a partner and ask them to name the four blocks without looking at your page.

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **character**: who the story is about
- **want**: what the character hopes for or tries to do
- **setting**: where and when the story takes place
- **problem**: the trouble that makes the story move

## Openings that catch a reader

### ● SWITCH ON

Which opening would make you keep reading? Talk, then vote with a quiet hand.

A. "Once upon a time there was a boy."

B. "The boat was already leaving when Marta realised the ticket was still on the kitchen table."

Why did you choose that one? Use the words *place*, *action* or *trouble* in your reason.

### ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

A strong **opening** does at least two of these jobs in the first few lines:

- puts you **in a place**
- shows a **character doing something**
- hints at **trouble** or a question
- uses a **precise detail** (a sound, an object, a time) instead of a vague start

Weak openings often start with empty labels:

- "This is a story about..."
- a long list of facts before anything happens
- vague time and place ("long ago", "far away") with no grip

You do not need a shout. You need a **hook**: a detail that makes the reader lean in.

### 🔄 REMEMBER

A hook is not always the loudest line. Sometimes it is the quietest true detail.

“ EXTRACT • THREE OPENINGS TO COMPARE

**Opening A** Tiago was a nice boy who lived in a house.

**Opening B** At 07:05 the tram doors shut on Tiago's sleeve. Lisbon was already moving without him.

**Opening C** Once, long ago, in a land far away, there lived a boy named Tiago who had many adventures.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Which opening is strongest, and why?

1. Opening A names a character but gives no clear place, want or problem. *Nice* is a label, not a precise trait.
2. Opening C is vague: "long ago", "far away", "many adventures" do not put us anywhere real.
3. Opening B gives **time** (07:05), **place** (Lisbon tram), **action** (doors shut on a sleeve) and **trouble** (left behind).

**Answer:** Opening B is strongest.

**Check it a different way:** Rewrite Opening A so it does the same job as B, without copying B's tram. Keep it under 30 words.

## AA LANGUAGE FOCUS: PRECISE WORDS

Swap empty words for precise ones.

| Empty | More precise                           |
|-------|----------------------------------------|
| nice  | careful, stubborn, shy, quick to laugh |
| went  | hurried, crept, stumbled, dashed       |
| thing | envelope, ticket, key, jar             |
| bad   | unfair, dangerous, lonely, late        |

In your notebook, improve three empty sentences of your own using this table as a model.

### • YOUR TURN

1. Rank openings A, B and C from strongest to weakest. Write one reason for your top choice.
2. Underline every **precise detail** in Opening B (time, place, object, action).
3. Rewrite Opening C so it starts in a real place in Portugal and shows trouble in the first two sentences.
4. Write two different openings for this idea: \*a girl finds a key that does not fit any door in her school\*. Keep each opening under 40 words.
5. Read your favourite opening aloud to a partner. Ask: "Would you turn the page?" Write their yes/no and one reason.
6. Stretch: take Opening B and write the **next** two sentences without solving the problem.

### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Collect three first lines from books at home or in class (write titles only in your notes, not long copied passages). Sort them into "hooks me" and "lets me go". Name the craft reason for one of each.

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **opening:** the first lines of a story
- **hook:** a detail or question that makes a reader want more
- **precise detail:** a clear, specific fact (time, object, place, sound)

#### UNIT 1 • TOPIC 1.3

## Setting and when

#### ● SWITCH ON

Close your eyes for ten seconds. Picture your favourite outdoor place. Open your eyes and tell a partner:

- one thing you can **see**
- one you can **hear**
- one you can **touch**

If your partner can almost stand in that place with you, your details are working.

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

**Setting** is where and when. Strong settings use the senses so a reader can stand in the scene.

Ask yourself:

- **Where** are we? (room, street, beach, hillside, kitchen, tram)
- **When** are we? (time of day, season, clock time if it helps)
- What can a character **sense**? (sight, sound, smell, touch, taste)

You do not need five senses in every sentence. Two or three true details beat ten empty adjectives (*beautiful, amazing, nice*).

**When** can be:

- a clock time: 14:30
- a part of the day: just after sunset
- a season: late October

Choose the kind of time that helps the story. A race against the bell needs a clock. A holiday memory might need a season.

“ EXTRACT · 'NIGHT MARKET' ”

The night market in Lagos smelled of grilled sardines and warm sugar. Strings of yellow bulbs swung over the stalls. Leonor's shoes stuck slightly to the sticky ground. Somewhere a radio played an old song. It was 21:10, and her brother was not where he said he would be.

## ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** List the setting details by sense and time.

| Sense / when | Detail                       |
|--------------|------------------------------|
| Smell        | grilled sardines, warm sugar |
| Sight        | yellow bulbs, stalls         |
| Touch        | sticky ground under shoes    |
| Hearing      | radio, old song              |
| When / where | 21:10 at night, Lagos        |

**Check it a different way:** Remove all sense words from the extract and read what is left. Notice how thin the scene becomes. Then put two sense words back and feel the difference.

## “ EXTRACT · SAME PLACE, WRONG TIME (TO FIX)

The night market in Lagos smelled of grilled sardines. It was 09:00 and the sun was high. Yellow bulbs glowed brightly in the midday sky. Leonor's shoes stuck to the sticky ground while morning joggers ran past.

## ► EDITOR'S EYE

The second extract mixes night details with morning time. That confuses a reader. When you change **when**, change the **details** that belong to that when.

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Copy a table with columns: see / hear / smell / touch. Fill it for the night market extract.
2. Rewrite the night market extract in the **morning** instead of night. Change at least four details so the time feels true.
3. Choose one setting: *a classroom before the bell*, *a ferry to the Algarve*, or *a rainy football pitch*. Write five sense notes, then turn them into three sentences.
4. Add a **problem** sentence to your three-sentence setting without using the word *problem*.
5. Partner check: can your partner draw a simple sketch of your setting from your sentences alone? If not, add one clearer detail.
6. Stretch: write two sentences that create a **tense** atmosphere, then two that create a **calm** atmosphere, using the same place (a school corridor).

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write the same event (someone loses a hat) in two settings: a busy train and a quiet library. Keep both under six sentences. Label which details do the work.

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **setting**: where and when a story takes place
- **senses**: sight, hearing, smell, touch, taste used to build a scene
- **atmosphere**: the feeling a setting creates (calm, tense, joyful)

# Planning your own opening

## ● SWITCH ON

In one minute, list three story ideas you could write. Star the one that interests you most today. Share only the starred idea with a partner. Listen to theirs without interrupting.

## ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

Before you write sentences, **plan**. A plan is a map, not the finished story.

Use this four-box plan for an opening (first half-page or so):

| Box          | Your notes                               |
|--------------|------------------------------------------|
| Character    | Name, age band, one trait                |
| Want         | What they try to do in the opening       |
| Setting      | Place + time + two sense details         |
| Problem seed | The first trouble (not the whole ending) |

Then write **only the opening**: roughly 8 to 15 sentences, or one strong page. Stop before you solve everything. Leave the reader wanting page two.

Draft in pencil. Cross out freely. The Writing Table likes messy first pages.

## 🔄 REMEMBER

If you invent the whole ending first, your opening may rush. Plan the seed of trouble, not the final cure.

## ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

### *Plan for a sample opening*

- Character: Rui, Year 4, careful with maps
- Want: to deliver a sealed envelope to the school office before 08:40
- Setting: school corridor, wet morning, smell of floor polish, squeaky shoes
- Problem seed: the envelope is blank; he does not know who it is for

### *Opening (fair draft):*

Rui held the envelope with both hands. The corridor smelled of floor polish and wet coats. It was 08:33. His shoes squeaked on every tile.

On the front of the envelope there was nothing: no name, no class, no room.

"Just take it to the office," his sister had said. But the office door was shut, and through the glass he could see nobody.

Rui turned the envelope over. Still blank. Outside, rain ticked against the high windows. He had seven minutes, and no idea what to do next.

**Check it a different way:** Mark character / want / setting / problem with four coloured dots in the margin of your notebook copy.

## ▢ WRITE-ON FRAME • FOUR-BOX PLAN

Copy this frame into your notebook and fill it for **your** starred idea.

Character: \_\_\_\_\_  
Trait: \_\_\_\_\_  
Want: \_\_\_\_\_  
Setting (place): \_\_\_\_\_  
Setting (when): \_\_\_\_\_  
Sense 1: \_\_\_\_\_  
Sense 2: \_\_\_\_\_  
Problem seed: \_\_\_\_\_  
Hook idea (one line): \_\_\_\_\_

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Fill the four-box plan for **your** starred idea (use the write-on frame).
2. Write a first draft of the opening (8 to 15 sentences).
3. Underline your **hook** sentence. If you cannot find one, write a better first or second sentence and replace it.
4. Swap drafts with a partner. On a sticky note (or notebook corner) write:
  - one detail that worked
  - one question you still have as a reader
5. Edit once: change at least three words to more precise ones (for example, *went* to *hurried*, *nice* to a clearer trait).
6. Stretch: cut two sentences that do no work. If the opening gets stronger, keep the cut.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write a second opening for the **same** plan but start in the middle of the action (no slow wake-up scene). Compare which draft hooks faster. Keep both.

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **plan:** notes that map a piece of writing before full sentences
- **problem seed:** the first trouble, not the whole ending
- **draft:** an early version you expect to improve
- **fair copy:** a neat final version of a piece of writing

# Along the way: first page of a story

## ★ UNIT PROJECT • FIRST PAGE OF A STORY

**Make:** the first page of an original story (fair copy).

**Length:** about 120 to 200 words, or one notebook page written carefully.

*Must include:*

1. A clear **character** and **want**
2. A **setting** with at least two sense details and a **when**
3. A **problem seed** (trouble begun, not fully solved)
4. A **title** of your own
5. A short **writer's note** under the story (two sentences):
  - what you wanted the reader to feel
  - one craft choice you made on purpose (hook, sense detail, precise verb...)

*Steps*

1. Use your plan from Topic 1.4 (or improve it).
2. Draft in pencil.
3. Read aloud to a partner. Change anything that trips your tongue.
4. Write a fair copy with a title.
5. Add the writer's note.
6. Share in a small group: each writer reads the **first three sentences** only; listeners say whether they want page two, and why.

*Success check*

- [ ] My opening has character, want, setting and problem seed
- [ ] I used precise details, not empty labels
- [ ] I can point to my hook
- [ ] My partner wanted to hear more
- [ ] My writer's note names one craft choice

### ▲ CHALLENGE • PEER REVIEW CARD

When you listen to a partner's first three sentences, complete this card:

1. I wanted page two: yes / not yet
2. Strongest detail I heard: \_\_\_\_\_
3. One question I still have: \_\_\_\_\_
4. Kind next step for the writer: \_\_\_\_\_

## What we learned • Unit 1

### ☑ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

Tick in your notebook if true for you now.

1. I can name the four building blocks of a story.
2. I can choose a strong opening and explain why.
3. I can build a setting with senses and time.
4. I can plan before I write.
5. I have a first page ready to share.

### ■ UNIT 1 WORD ROUND-UP

character • want • setting • problem • opening • hook • precise detail • senses • atmosphere • plan • problem seed • draft • fair copy

### → LOOKING AHEAD

In Unit 2 you will put **voices** on the page: narrative, dialogue and a short playscript. Bring your first-page story with you. You may give your character something to say.

*Read carefully. Write clearly. Share the page.*



## Unit 2 • Characters who speak

## Unit 2 • Characters who speak

*Narrative, dialogue and playscripts: putting voices on the page*

### ⊙ IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- Tell narrative from dialogue in a short extract.
- Punctuate speech so readers know who is talking.
- Show what a character wants through what they say and do.
- Read and write a short playscript.
- Create a two-voice scene as a unit project.

### UNIT 2 • TOPIC 2.1

## Narrative and dialogue

### ● SWITCH ON

With a partner, act this out in two voices, then swap roles:

A: "Is that your bag on the bus seat?" B: "Yes. Why?" A: "Because the bus is leaving, and you are still on the pavement."

What did you understand that was **not** written as a full story paragraph?

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

A story uses two kinds of writing:

- **Narrative:** the storyteller's voice. It tells what happens, what is seen, and sometimes what a character thinks.
- **Dialogue:** the characters' own words, usually inside **speech marks**.

Narrative can show action: *Beatriz ran*. Dialogue lets us hear a person: *"Wait for me!"*

Good pages mix both. Too much dialogue with no narrative can feel like floating voices. Too much narrative with no dialogue can feel distant.

“ EXTRACT · 'THE LAST ORANGE' ”

The market was packing away. Beatriz counted her coins twice.

"How much for the last orange?" she asked.

The seller wiped his hands on his apron. "Fifty cents," he said, "and it is sweeter than it looks."

Beatriz hesitated. Rain tapped the canvas roof. She needed the orange for her brother's lunch, and she had exactly fifty cents left.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Label each sentence N (narrative) or D (dialogue).

1. The market was packing away. → N
2. "How much for the last orange?" she asked. → D (+ small narrative tag)
3. Rain tapped the canvas roof. → N

**Check it a different way:** Read only the dialogue lines aloud. Then read only the narrative. Notice what each kind of writing gives you.

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Copy two narrative sentences and two dialogue sentences from the extract.
2. Write one new narrative sentence that shows Beatriz is worried **without** using the word *worried*.
3. Write one new dialogue line for the seller that makes him kinder, and one that makes him ruder. Keep speech marks correct.
4. Turn this narrative into dialogue between two characters:  
*Diogo wanted the window seat. His sister got there first.*
5. Partner work: one person reads narrative only; the other adds dialogue tags by ear, then check the page.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Rewrite the extract with **no dialogue**, only narrative. Then rewrite it with **mostly dialogue** and minimal narrative. Which version is clearer for a Year 4 reader, and why?

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **narrative:** the storyteller's voice telling what happens
- **dialogue:** the words characters say
- **speech marks:** the marks that wrap spoken words ("...")

#### UNIT 2 • TOPIC 2.2

### Speech marks that behave

#### ● SWITCH ON

Which line is written correctly? Vote, then explain.

A. "Come here, said Ana. B. "Come here," said Ana. C. Come here," said Ana."

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

British English speech punctuation follows a calm pattern:

1. Open speech marks before the first spoken word.
2. End the spoken sentence with a comma, question mark or exclamation mark **inside** the speech marks when a **said**-tag follows.
3. Close speech marks.
4. Add the tag: *said Ana, asked Joao, whispered the guide.*
5. New speaker, new line.

Examples:

- "The ferry is late," said Ana.
- "Is the ferry late?" asked Joao.
- "It is never late!" shouted the guide.

If the tag comes first: *Ana said, "The ferry is late."*

Start a new line each time the speaker changes. That is not decoration. It is how readers keep track of who is talking.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Broken line:** the map is upside down said nina

*Repair steps:*

1. Add speech marks around the spoken words.
2. Add a comma before the closing marks.
3. Capitalise names and the first spoken word.
4. Add the tag.

**Fixed:** "The map is upside down," said Nina.

**Check it a different way:** Write the same idea as a question: "Is the map upside down?" asked Nina.

- YOUR TURN

1. Correct these lines in your notebook:

1. where is my pencil asked rafa
2. "I have it said Maya
3. Stop running yelled the coach

2. Write a three-line dialogue (two speakers) about missing the school bus. Use a new line for each speaker.

3. Add a narrative sentence before your dialogue to set the place and time.

4. Swap with a partner. Circle any missing speech marks or new-line mistakes.

5. Stretch: write one line where the tag comes **before** the speech.

→ GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write a dialogue of six lines with **three** speakers. Keep new lines clear. At the end, list who spoke most and whether that matches their role in the scene.

■ KEY WORDS

- **speech tag**: words like *said, asked, whispered* that show who spoke
- **new line rule**: start a new line when the speaker changes

## What a character wants

### ● SWITCH ON

Listen while your teacher reads two lines in different voices:

1. "Fine. Take the last seat."
2. "Please, could I sit there? My knee hurts today."

What does each speaker **want**, and how do you know?

### ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

Characters become real when we know what they **want** in a scene.

Want can be big (*to find a lost sister*) or small (*to borrow a rubber*). On the page, want shows up through:

- **dialogue** (what they ask for or refuse)
- **action** (what they do with their hands and feet)
- **choice** (what they pick when two things compete)

Do not only label: "She was angry." Let speech and action carry the feeling.

### “ EXTRACT · ‘QUEUE AT THE FOUNTAIN’

The queue for the water fountain snaked across the playground. Miguel held an empty bottle. In front of him, a taller boy filled a bottle, then began to fill a second.

"One bottle each," Miguel said, not loudly.

The taller boy did not turn. "I was here first."

Miguel looked at the clock above the door. Five minutes until the bell. He stepped aside, then stepped back, bottle tight in both hands.

### ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** What does Miguel want, and what evidence shows it?

1. Want: water in his bottle before the bell / fair turn at the fountain.
2. Evidence: empty bottle; "One bottle each"; watching the clock; stepping back into the queue.

**Check it a different way:** Write one dialogue line that would make Miguel's want clearer without a long speech.

### ● YOUR TURN

1. In the extract, highlight (or copy) two clues to Miguel's want.
2. Write what the taller boy wants in one sentence. Is it fair? Explain in two sentences.
3. Rewrite the taller boy's line so he becomes more reasonable, then rewrite it so he becomes more selfish. Keep speech marks correct.
4. Plan a tiny scene (four-box: character, want, setting, problem) about **sharing art materials** at The Writing Table.
5. Write the scene in 8 to 12 lines, mixing narrative and dialogue.

### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Take your Unit 1 first-page story. Add **four lines of dialogue** that reveal your character's want more clearly than narration alone.

### ■ KEY WORDS

- **motivation:** another word for what a character wants and why
- **show, not label:** use speech and action instead of only naming a feeling

# A short playscript

## ● SWITCH ON

In groups of three, read this aloud once, then swap parts:

**NIA:** Is the hall free? **OMAR:** Only until lunch. **NIA:** Then we practise now. **STAGE DIRECTION:** *They drag two chairs into a circle.*

## ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

A **playscript** is writing meant to be performed. It looks different from a story page:

- Character names in capital letters (or bold) before each line
- Little or no speech marks
- **Stage directions** in italics (or brackets) for actions, not speech
- Short lines that actors can say clearly

Playscripts still need want and problem. They just show them through spoken lines and actions you can see.

## “ EXTRACT • PLAYSRIPT • 'LOST PERMISSION SLIP' ”

**SETTING:** School cloakroom, morning.

**LARA:** It was in this pocket. It was. **TOMAS:** Check the other pocket. **LARA:** I did. Twice.

**TOMAS:** *(kneeling, searching the floor)* Blue paper or white? **LARA:** Blue. With my mum's signature. **TOMAS:** Then we retrace your steps. Bag. Desk. Bus seat. **LARA:** If I do not find it, I miss the museum. **TOMAS:** Then stop talking and start looking. I will help.

### ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** What is Lara's want, and which stage direction helps the scene?

1. Want: find the permission slip so she can go to the museum.
2. Stage direction: Tomas kneeling and searching shows action, not just talk.

**Check it a different way:** Turn Tomas's last line into story dialogue with speech marks and a tag. Notice how the playscript form is leaner.

### • YOUR TURN

1. List three differences between a story page and a playscript.
2. Add two new lines to the extract (one for Lara, one for Tomas) that raise the urgency without shouting every word.
3. Write a stage direction that shows Lara is close to giving up (action, not a feeling label).
4. In pairs, perform the extract once for speed and once for clear feeling. Note one line that was hard to say and improve it.
5. Convert four lines of your Unit 1 story into playscript form.

### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write a 10-line playscript for two characters who disagree about whether to tell a teacher about a broken window. End on a decision, not a full solution.

### ■ KEY WORDS

- **playscript:** text written for performance
- **stage direction:** an instruction for action or movement, not spoken aloud

## Along the way: two voices on the page

### ★ UNIT PROJECT

**Make:** a short scene with exactly **two** speaking characters.

*Choose one form:*

- **Form A:** story page (narrative + dialogue), 120 to 180 words
- **Form B:** playscript, 12 to 20 spoken lines plus stage directions

*Must include:*

1. Two clear wants (one per character), even if they conflict
2. Correct speech layout for your chosen form
3. A setting stated in narrative or in a SETTING line
4. A title
5. A performance or read-aloud for another pair

*Steps*

1. Plan wants first (two sentences).
2. Draft the scene.
3. Check new-line rules / playscript names.
4. Rehearse once. Cut any line that does no work.
5. Fair copy.
6. Perform or read for another pair. Listeners name each character's want.

*Success check*

- [ ] Two distinct voices
- [ ] Speech layout is correct for the form
- [ ] Wants are clear without a long explanation paragraph
- [ ] Listeners could state both wants

## What we learned • Unit 2

### ☑ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

1. I can separate narrative and dialogue.
2. I can punctuate speech and start a new line for a new speaker.
3. I can show what a character wants through speech and action.
4. I can read and write a short playscript.
5. I have a two-voice scene ready to share.

### ■ UNIT 2 WORD ROUND-UP

narrative • dialogue • speech marks • speech tag • new line rule • motivation • show, not label • playscript • stage direction

### → LOOKING AHEAD

Unit 3 turns from speech to **sound on the page**: poems, rhythm, line breaks and images that stick in the mind.



## Unit 3 • Poems and word music

## Unit 3 • Poems and word music

*Sound, image and performance: making poems that live in the ear*

### 🕒 IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- Explain what a poem can do that a story paragraph does differently.
- Use rhythm, sound patterns and line breaks on purpose.
- Build strong images with careful word choice.
- Try shape and pattern poems.
- Write and perform a class poem.

### UNIT 3 • TOPIC 3.1

## What a poem can do

### 🕒 SWITCH ON

Your teacher reads a short poem twice: once in a rush, once slowly. After each reading, write one word for how it felt. Did the speed change the meaning?

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

A **poem** is writing that cares about **sound**, **shape on the page**, and **image**, not only about information.

A story often asks: *What happened next?* A poem often asks: *How does this feel, sound or look up close?*

Poems may:

- use short lines
- repeat words or sounds
- leave white space
- say a lot with few words

Poems do not have to rhyme. Rhyme is a tool, not a rule.

“ EXTRACT · POEM · 'WINDOW SEAT' ”

Rain draws thin rivers on the tram glass. My bag holds a cold apple and tomorrow's spelling list. Somewhere between stops I forget which station is mine and watch the wet city write itself again.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** What can this poem do that a report about a tram ride might not?

1. It slows a small moment (rain on glass, cold apple).
2. It uses line breaks to control breath and attention.
3. It ends on an image, not a timetable fact.

**Check it a different way:** Rewrite the poem as three plain sentences. Notice what is gained and what is lost.

#### ● YOUR TURN

1. In the poem, circle three words that create a clear picture.
2. Write one sentence: *This poem is mainly about...* (do not use more than twelve words).
3. Change the setting from a tram to a ferry. Rewrite four lines, keeping the same quiet mood.
4. With a partner, take turns reading the original poem. Mark a slash / where you naturally breathe.
5. List two things a poem can do and two things a story can do. Share one example of each from your own reading.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Find a short poem at home or in class. Copy four lines carefully. Under them, write what the poem does to you as a reader (one sentence only).

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **poem:** writing that uses sound, line and image with special care
- **line:** a row of words in a poem; it may be shorter than a sentence
- **rhyme:** words that share end sounds (optional in poems)

### UNIT 3 • TOPIC 3.2

## Sound, rhythm and line breaks

#### ● SWITCH ON

Clap the beat while you say:

*hop hop hop / stop whisper whisper / shout*

Which felt faster? Which felt louder? Words have body, not only meaning.

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

**Rhythm** is the beat of a line: short beats, long beats, pauses.

**Sound patterns** you can use on purpose:

- **alliteration**: same start sound (*silver sardines*)
- **repetition**: a word or phrase returns (*again and again*)
- **onomatopoeia**: a word that sounds like its meaning (*hiss, clatter*)

A **line break** is where the line stops. Breaking after an important word can make a reader notice it. Breaking in a surprising place can create a small jump.

Read every draft aloud. If you trip, the line probably needs a break or a stronger word.

“ EXTRACT · POEM · ‘KITCHEN MORNING’

Kettle ticks. Toast pops. Knife clinks the jar. Someone laughs in the hallway and the day begins in crumbs.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Where does sound do the work?

1. *ticks/pops/clinks*: onomatopoeia and short beats
2. Line breaks after *laughs* and *days* slow the ending
3. Final image *in crumbs* lands because it is alone enough to notice

**Check it a different way:** Write the poem as one paragraph with commas. Read both versions aloud.

#### ● YOUR TURN

1. List three onomatopoeic words for a school playground at break.
2. Write a four-line poem that uses alliteration at least twice (topic: rain, or football, or a busy corridor).
3. Take this sentence and break it into a poem of at least five lines:  
*The library was quiet until someone dropped a box of pencils.*
4. Partner read: ask your partner to clap only on the stressed words they hear.
5. Improve one line by changing a dull verb (*went, was, did*) into a more precise verb.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write two versions of the same four-line poem: one with mostly short words, one with longer words. Which fits a storm better? Which fits falling asleep?

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **rhythm:** the beat and pace of a line
- **alliteration:** repeated starting sounds
- **onomatopoeia:** words that sound like their meaning
- **line break:** the place where a line of poetry ends

#### UNIT 3 • TOPIC 3.3

## Images that stick

#### ● SWITCH ON

Which picture stays in your mind longer?

A. *The moon was nice.* B. *The moon was a pale coin above the harbour.*

Explain your choice in one sentence.

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

An **image** in poetry is a word-picture. It is not always a metaphor homework label. It is any detail that lets a reader see, hear or feel clearly.

Tools:

- **precise noun:** *harbour*, not just *place*
- **strong verb:** *spills*, not only *is*
- **comparison** when useful: *like a pale coin* (simile) or \*the moon, a pale coin\* (metaphor)

One true image is better than five decorations. Avoid piling adjectives that fight each other (*dark bright huge tiny night*).

“ EXTRACT · POEM · 'AFTER THE MATCH' ”

Mud maps my shins. The ball sleeps in the net like a spent moon. Somebody's water bottle rolls a slow circle and stops at my foot as if it chose me.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Which images stick, and why?

1. *Mud maps my shins*: mud as map is unexpected and visual.
2. *ball sleeps... spent moon*: quiet after action.
3. Bottle *chose me*: small ending image with a hint of story.

**Check it a different way:** Replace *sleeps* with *is*. Notice the energy drop.

- YOUR TURN

1. Underline three images in the extract.
2. Improve these dull lines with one strong image each:
  1. The sea was big.
  2. My bag was heavy.
  3. The classroom was messy.
3. Write a six-line poem called *My street at 18:00*. Include at least two sticky images. No need to rhyme.
4. Remove two weak adjectives from your draft and replace them with a better noun or verb.
5. Gallery walk: leave your poem on the desk; classmates place a tick beside the image that stayed with them.

→ GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write a poem of eight lines that contains **no adjectives**. Use only nouns, verbs and small linking words. Read it aloud. What still paints a picture?

■ KEY WORDS

- **image**: a clear word-picture in the reader's mind
- **simile**: a comparison using *like* or *as*
- **metaphor**: a comparison that says one thing *is* another

# Shape and pattern poems

## ● SWITCH ON

Look at words arranged as a staircase on the board (or in the air with a finger). How does the shape change how you read the speed of the words?

## ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

Some poems use **pattern** or **shape** as part of meaning:

- a list poem with a repeated starter (*I remember...*)
- a counting pattern (one detail, then two, then three)
- a shape poem where the lines form a simple outline (a leaf, a wave, a bottle)

Shape should help meaning, not replace it. A beautiful outline with empty words is still empty. Start with strong words, then fit the shape.

For print in a student book, keep shapes simple so they stay readable.

## “ EXTRACT · PATTERN POEM · 'I KEEP' ”

I keep a smooth stone from the beach at Cascais. I keep a bus ticket folded into a square. I keep my brother's joke that still works on rainy days. I keep the word *almost* when I am learning something hard. I keep quiet for one minute when the sky turns copper. I keep starting again at The Writing Table.

## ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** What is the pattern, and what does the last line do?

1. Pattern: each line starts with *I keep* (except the turn at the end).
2. The list moves from objects to feelings to a place of work.
3. The last line names the book's identity and lands the list.

**Check it a different way:** Write three *I keep* lines of your own in one minute without stopping.

- YOUR TURN

1. Write a list poem of six lines with a repeated starter (*I hear...*, or *\*In my pocket...\**, or *On Mondays...*).
2. Choose a simple shape (circle of waves, tall tree, winding path). Draft eight words that belong to that idea first, then arrange them on the page.
3. Partner test: can your partner guess the shape from the words alone before you explain?
4. Perform your list poem with a group echo on the repeated starter.
5. Edit for sound: change one line that feels flat when spoken.

→ GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Turn your Unit 1 story opening into a six-line list poem that keeps the problem seed. Title both versions and say which form fits the idea better.

- KEY WORDS

- **list poem:** a poem built from a patterned list
- **shape poem:** a poem whose layout on the page suggests its subject
- **pattern:** a repeating structure a reader can follow

# Along the way: a class poem to perform

## ★ UNIT PROJECT

**Make:** one **class poem** (shared writing) and one **solo verse** from each pupil that can stand alone or join the class poem.

### *Class poem (shared)*

1. Choose a subject linked to school life (break time, the library, the way home, rain on the pitch).
2. Gather sticky images on the board (twenty words minimum).
3. Build 8 to 12 lines together, reading aloud after every two lines.
4. Decide on one sound tool to feature (repetition, alliteration, or onomatopoeia).
5. Rehearse as a chorus: some lines solo, some tutti.

### *Solo verse*

- Four to six lines on the same subject from your own viewpoint
- At least one sticky image
- A clear title

### *Performance*

- Stand so the audience can hear consonants
- Pause at line breaks
- Do not race

### *Success check*

- [ ] Class poem uses sound on purpose
- [ ] My solo verse has a sticky image
- [ ] We performed without rushing the last line
- [ ] I can name one craft choice we made as a class

## What we learned • Unit 3

### ☑ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

1. I can say what a poem can do.
2. I can use rhythm, sound and line breaks on purpose.
3. I can build images that stick.
4. I can write a simple pattern or shape poem.
5. I have performed poetry with care.

### ■ UNIT 3 WORD ROUND-UP

poem • line • rhyme • rhythm • alliteration • onomatopoeia • line break • image • simile • metaphor • list poem • shape poem • pattern

### → LOOKING AHEAD

Unit 4 leaves the music of poetry for the clear tools of **information**: headings, captions, facts in your own words, and explanations people can follow.



## Unit 4 • Finding things out

## Unit 4 • Finding things out

*Information texts: headings, facts and explanations you can trust*

### ⊙ IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- Read information texts to find answers, not only to enjoy a story.
- Use headings, captions and labels as navigation tools.
- Put facts into your own words without copying whole sentences.
- Write explanation steps another person can follow.
- Create an explanation of something you know well.

### UNIT 4 • TOPIC 4.1

## Reading to find things out

### ● SWITCH ON

You have two minutes and a page about bees (your teacher will show or read a short information paragraph). Your only job: find **what bees collect from flowers**. Do not retell the whole page. Write the answer in one sentence.

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

**Information reading** is different from story reading.

In a story you often ask: *What will happen?* In information text you often ask: *What do I need to know?*

Useful moves:

1. Read the **question** first (what are you looking for?).
2. Scan headings and first sentences.
3. Slow down when you hit the answer zone.
4. Check you can say the answer **in your own words**.

Copying a long sentence you do not understand is not finding out. Understanding is the goal.

“ EXTRACT · INFORMATION · 'CORK OAK FACTS' ”

Cork oaks grow in Portugal and other parts of the western Mediterranean. Their thick bark can be harvested without cutting the tree down. After harvest, the tree grows new bark over several years. Cork is light, keeps water out, and is used for stoppers, floors and noticeboards. Portugal is one of the world's leading cork producers.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** What can cork bark be used for?

1. Scan for *used for*.
2. Find: stoppers, floors and noticeboards.
3. Own words: \*People use cork for bottle stoppers, flooring and boards for notices.\*

**Check it a different way:** Answer a second question from the same text: *Does harvesting cork kill the tree?* Find evidence, then answer in a full sentence.

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Write two questions the cork extract can answer and one question it cannot.
2. Find and copy the sentence that proves cork keeps water out. Then rewrite it in fewer words.
3. True or false? *Cork oaks grow only in Portugal.* Use evidence from the text.
4. With a partner, make a three-box chart: Fact I found / Words from the text / My own sentence.
5. Bring one object from your pencil case. Write two information questions about it that a classmate could research later.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Read a short page in a non-fiction book. Write three questions before reading, then mark which ones the page answered. For unanswered questions, say where you might look next (person, book section, safe site with a teacher).

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **information text:** writing that explains or informs rather than tells a story
- **scan:** look quickly for a key word or answer
- **evidence:** words in the text that support an answer

#### UNIT 4 • TOPIC 4.2

## Headings, captions and labels

#### ● SWITCH ON

Look at a labelled diagram your teacher shows (a plant, a bicycle, or a classroom map). Without reading the main paragraph, list three things you already understand from the **labels** alone.

#### ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

Information pages often use navigation tools:

- **Heading:** the title of a section; tells you the topic
- **Subheading:** a smaller title inside a section
- **Caption:** words under a picture that explain what you see
- **Label:** a short word or phrase joined to part of a diagram

These tools are not decoration. They are a map. Good readers use the map before they sink into every sentence.

When you write information text, your headings should be honest. A heading that promises "How to care for a goldfish" must teach care, not a random fish story.

#### “ EXTRACT · PAGE MAP · 'SCHOOL GARDEN' ”

**Heading:** Our school garden

**Subheading:** What grows in spring

In March and April, the garden team plants lettuce, peas and herbs in the raised beds near the south wall.

**Caption under photo:** Year 4 pupils water the pea seedlings after lunch (12:40).

**Labels on diagram:** water butt · compost bay · herb trough · path

#### ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Where would you look first to learn *when* pupils water seedlings?

1. Caption includes time 12:40 and the action *water*.
2. The subheading tells the season, not the clock time.
3. Labels name places, not times.

**Answer:** Start with the caption.

**Check it a different way:** Write a better subheading for a section about compost, using three words or fewer.

#### ● YOUR TURN

1. Match each tool to its job: heading, caption, label (write one job each).
2. Improve this weak heading: *Stuff about space*. Make it specific for a page on the Moon.
3. Write three labels for a diagram of a school bag (choose useful parts).
4. Write a caption for a photo of children reading under a tree. Include who, what and one precise detail.
5. Partner challenge: one person writes a messy paragraph; the other adds a heading, one subheading and a caption line that would help a reader.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Redesign the contents line for Unit 4 as if it were an information poster: main heading, three subheadings, two caption ideas for images you would want.

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **heading**: section title that names the topic
- **caption**: explanation under a picture
- **label**: short name attached to part of a diagram

#### UNIT 4 • TOPIC 4.3

## Facts in your own words

#### ● SWITCH ON

Listen to a two-sentence fact your teacher reads once. Whisper it back to a partner **without** using the same first four words. That is the start of putting facts in your own words.

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

Putting a fact **in your own words** means you understand it well enough to rebuild it.

Steps that help:

1. Read the fact twice.
2. Cover it.
3. Say it aloud from memory.
4. Write your sentence.
5. Check you kept the meaning and did not copy a long string of words.

Changing one word is not enough. Borrowing a whole sentence and swapping *large* for *big* is still copying.

You may keep special names (Portugal, cork oak) because they are the accurate names, not decorative synonyms.

“ EXTRACT · FACTS · 'TRAMS IN LISBON' ”

Lisbon's yellow trams are a famous part of the city. Some lines climb steep hills that are hard for buses. Trams share the road with cars, so drivers and passengers must watch carefully. Many visitors ride the old trams, but local people use them for ordinary journeys too.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Fact from text:** Some lines climb steep hills that are hard for buses.

**Own words:** *Certain tram routes go up hills that buses struggle to manage.*

**Too close (not good enough):** *Some lines climb steep hills that are hard for buses.*  
(copied)

**Check it a different way:** Own-word a second fact about local people and visitors.

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Own-word two facts from the tram extract.
2. Mark each of your sentences C (too copied) or O (own words) after a partner check. Fix any C.
3. Write one fact about your school day that is true, and one sentence that is an opinion. Label them Fact / Opinion.
4. From the cork extract in Topic 4.1, write three own-word facts. Do not look back until you have finished each sentence.
5. Stretch: combine two tram facts into one longer sentence without losing accuracy.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Choose a short paragraph from any information book. Write a three-bullet summary using only own words. Then list three words you kept on purpose (names or key terms).

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **fact:** something that can be checked and shown to be true
- **opinion:** a belief or feeling that can differ between people
- **paraphrase:** say the same meaning in different words

#### UNIT 4 • TOPIC 4.4

### Explanation steps that make sense

#### ● SWITCH ON

In order, tell a partner how to tie a shoelace **or** how to open your school bag and find a pencil. If your partner gets lost, your steps need work.

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

An **explanation** tells how or why something happens, often in clear steps.

Good explanations:

- start with what you are explaining
- use order words (*first, next, then, finally*) when sequence matters
- use precise verbs
- do not skip a step a new person would need
- end when the goal is complete

Explanations are not stories. You usually do not need a dramatic problem. You need a path a reader can follow.

“ EXTRACT · EXPLANATION · ‘HOW TO POT A HERB’

How to pot a small herb plant

First, choose a pot with a hole at the bottom so extra water can escape. Next, cover the hole with a small stone and add potting soil until the pot is half full. Then place the herb in the centre and fill around the roots with more soil. Press gently. Finally, water until you see a little water leave the bottom hole, and set the pot in a bright place indoors.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Why is the stone step there?

1. The text says the pot needs a hole for water to escape.
2. The stone helps keep soil from blocking the hole (practical reason taught in many gardening guides; state it as classroom practice with teacher support).

**Order check:** If you water before there is a hole path, roots can sit in water. Sequence matters.

**Check it a different way:** Number the steps 1 to 5 in the margin.

• YOUR TURN

1. Add one warning sentence to the herb explanation (what not to do).
2. Write an explanation with four steps: *How to borrow a library book* (or your school's real process).
3. Remove order words from your explanation and ask a partner to reorder the steps. If they fail, your steps need clearer verbs or numbers.
4. Turn this muddled list into a clean explanation:
  - eat the sandwich
  - wash hands
  - open lunchbox
  - sit down
5. Write a *why* sentence: why washing hands comes before eating.

→ GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write two explanations of the same task: one for a Year 1 pupil, one for a grown-up. Keep the facts accurate. Change only clarity and detail.

■ KEY WORDS

- **explanation:** writing that shows how or why something works
- **sequence:** the order of steps
- **precise verb:** a verb that names the exact action

## Along the way: explain something you know

### ★ UNIT PROJECT

**Make:** a one-page explanation of something you can already do or know well.

*Ideas (pick one):*

- how to care for a class pet or plant
- how to get ready for PE
- how a simple game at break works
- how to make a favourite simple snack (with adult safety rules)
- how to organise your desk at The Writing Table

*Must include:*

1. A clear heading
2. A short introduction (what this explains and who it helps)
3. Numbered steps or order words (at least four steps)
4. One diagram **or** three labels **or** one captioned picture plan
5. A final "Check" box: how a reader knows they succeeded
6. Own words only (no copied internet paragraphs)

*Steps*

1. Choose the topic and list steps roughly.
2. Test the steps on a partner who does not know the task.
3. Fix any missing step.
4. Add heading, intro and check box.
5. Fair copy.

*Success check*

- [ ] A partner could follow my steps without asking more than one question
- [ ] Heading matches content
- [ ] Steps are in a sensible order

- [ ] I used my own words

## What we learned • Unit 4

### ☑ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

1. I can read to find a specific answer.
2. I can use headings, captions and labels.
3. I can put facts in my own words.
4. I can write explanation steps another person can follow.
5. I have a one-page explanation ready to share.

### ■ UNIT 4 WORD ROUND-UP

information text · scan · evidence · heading · caption · label · fact · opinion · paraphrase · explanation · sequence · precise verb

### → LOOKING AHEAD

Unit 5 returns to story, but older story: **traditional tales**, patterns, heroes and retelling with a twist for a younger audience.



# Unit 5 • Traditional tales

## Unit 5 • Traditional tales

*Old stories that travel: pattern, roles and retelling with care*

### ⦿ IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- Explain how traditional tales travel across places and generations.
- Spot heroes, helpers and trouble in a tale.
- Use pattern and repetition as storytelling tools.
- Retell a tale with a clear twist while keeping its heart.
- Prepare a tale for a younger class.

### UNIT 5 • TOPIC 5.1

## How traditional tales travel

### ● SWITCH ON

Has a grown-up ever told you a story that begins *When I was your age...* or *My grandmother said...?* Share one line you remember. Where did that story come from before it reached you?

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

**Traditional tales** are stories that communities pass on. They include fairy tales, folk tales, fables and local legends. They change a little with each teller, yet keep a recognisable heart.

Tales travel by:

- voice (told aloud)
- page (written or printed versions)
- performance (plays, puppet shows)
- family memory

Because they travel, you may meet the same pattern in different clothes: a lost child, a clever animal, a difficult task, a kind stranger. Your job as a Year 4 writer is not to copy a published book word for word. Your job is to know the pattern, then retell in **your own words** with respect for the tale's core.

“ EXTRACT · MINI-TALE · 'THE BASKET OF WIND' (ORIGINAL PRIME RETELLING

in the spirit of travelling folk motifs, not a copy of a single published text)

Long ago, on a hill above a river, a child named Lio was given a woven basket and one rule: never open it on the bridge.

Halfway across, the wind tugged Lio's hair. "Just a look," Lio whispered.

The lid lifted. Out rushed a weather that knocked the river into white peaks. Lio slammed the lid, but the bridge was already singing with storm.

An old ferry worker pulled Lio to the bank. "Some gifts are heavier when opened," she said. "Next time, carry the rule as carefully as the basket."

### ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** What travelled in this tale: objects, rules, or both?

1. Object: the basket
2. Rule: never open it on the bridge
3. Lesson-shaped ending: the ferry worker's line

**Check it a different way:** Tell the tale in exactly three sentences without using the name Lio.

### ● YOUR TURN

1. Define *traditional tale* in your own words (one or two sentences).
2. List three ways a tale can travel to a new listener.
3. In the extract, what is the rule, and what happens when it is broken?
4. Interview a partner: name one story known in their family. Write two sentences about how it arrived (who told it, when).
5. Why should we retell in our own words instead of copying a book page? Write three bullet reasons.

### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Map a tale's journey as a simple chain: *first teller* → *next teller* → *me*. Leave question marks where you do not know. Research only with a teacher's help if you want a real traditional title's origin notes.

### ■ KEY WORDS

- **traditional tale:** a story passed through a community over time
- **retell:** tell again in your own words
- **motif:** a repeated story ingredient (a rule, a test, a helper)

## Heroes, helpers and trouble

### ● SWITCH ON

In a story you know, who tries hardest to solve the problem? Who helps? What stands in the way? Use three fingers to assign: hero / helper / trouble.

### ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

Many traditional tales use clear roles:

- **Hero** (or main character): the one who faces the problem and changes
- **Helper**: a person, animal or object that supports the hero
- **Trouble**: the problem, villain, obstacle or hard rule

Roles can flip. A helper might cause trouble by mistake. A hero might begin selfish and grow kinder. Naming roles helps you plan a retelling that does not wander.

### “ EXTRACT • ROLE MAP • ‘THE LANTERN THAT WOULD NOT LIGHT’

In the fishing village, Noa's lantern failed on the night the boats needed a signal on the rocks. Noa climbed the path with cold fingers. A gull dropped a dry scrap of cloth at Noa's feet. An old net-mender showed how to shield the flame from wind. Below, the dark water waited, and one boat still had not come in.

### ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

*Roles:*

1. Hero: Noa (acts to solve the signal problem)
2. Helpers: gull (cloth), net-mender (skill)
3. Trouble: lantern fails; wind; boat still out

**Check it a different way:** Rewrite one sentence to make the net-mender the hero instead, changing as little as possible.

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Fill a table for the lantern extract: hero / helper / trouble.
2. Add one new helper (not a person) and write two sentences showing the help.
3. Create a role card for a new tale set in a Portuguese primary school: character names, want, trouble, one helper.
4. In pairs, improvise a 30-second version using only the role cards.
5. Write a paragraph where the helper arrives late. How does that change the tension?

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Take 'The basket of wind'. Argue in four sentences that the ferry worker is the true hero. Then argue the opposite. Which argument is stronger?

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **hero:** main character who faces the central problem
- **helper:** character or force that supports the hero
- **trouble:** the obstacle, threat or problem driving the tale

#### UNIT 5 • TOPIC 5.3

## Pattern and repetition

#### ● SWITCH ON

Say this pattern aloud and continue it one more time:

*Knock once for hope. Knock twice for help. Knock three times for...*

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

Traditional tales love **pattern**:

- three tasks
- three visits
- a repeated phrase
- a rule said more than once

Repetition helps listeners remember and feel rhythm building toward a change. The third time is often different: success, failure, or surprise.

When you retell, keep a pattern strong enough to hear, but do not bore your audience. Vary one detail each repeat so the pattern grows.

“ EXTRACT · PATTERN · 'THREE KNOCKS AT THE BAKERY' ”

At dawn, a traveller knocked once on the bakery door in Evora. "I ask for crumbs," he said. The baker gave a dry end of loaf.

At noon, the traveller knocked twice. "I ask for crust," he said. The baker gave a wider slice.

At dusk, the traveller knocked three times. "I ask to learn," he said. The baker put a tray in his hands. "Then knead," she replied, "and warm the morning for someone else."

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

*Pattern parts:*

1. Time of day changes (dawn, noon, dusk)
2. Knocks increase (one, two, three)
3. Request grows (crumbs, crust, learning)
4. Outcome grows (end of loaf, wider slice, a chance to work)

**Check it a different way:** Clap on each repeated structure as someone reads.

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Underline the repeated sentence frames in the bakery extract.
2. Write a three-visit pattern set at a library desk (what is asked each time?).
3. Change only the third visit so the ending surprises without breaking the pattern.
4. Group reading: assign narrator, traveller, baker. Perform once, then swap.
5. Invent a repeated rule line for a new tale (eight words or fewer) and use it twice in a short paragraph.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Compress the bakery tale into six lines of poetry that keep the three-visit pattern. Keep meaning; cut extra words.

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **pattern:** a repeating structure in a story
- **repetition:** words or events that return on purpose
- **build:** how each repeat grows stronger or changes

#### UNIT 5 • TOPIC 5.4

### Retell with a new twist

#### ● SWITCH ON

If Cinderella's slipper were a sports trainer, what else would have to change for the story to still make sense? List three changes quickly.

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

A **twist** is a deliberate change that makes a retelling yours:

- new setting (a coastal school, a mountain village)
- new time (today, with phones carefully used)
- swapped roles (the helper becomes the hero)
- new problem with the same heart (kindness, courage, fairness)

Keep the **heart**: the big idea the tale cares about. Change the **clothes**: names, places, objects, era.

Do not twist so hard that the story becomes mean without purpose, or copies a film scene you only half remember. Write cleanly. Credit that your version is a retelling inspired by traditional patterns.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Base heart of 'The basket of wind':** a rule exists to protect people; breaking it brings a cost; wisdom arrives through consequence and guidance.

*Twist plan:*

- Setting: school science fair
- Object: a sealed weather model on a table
- Rule: do not remove the cover before judging
- Twist: a curious friend lifts the cover "just to check"

**Opening line for retelling:** "Do not lift the cover," Ms Costa said, "until the judges arrive at 14:00."

**Check it a different way:** Write the moral in seven words or fewer without sounding like a lecture.

#### • YOUR TURN

1. Choose a traditional pattern you know (three tasks, lost object, clever animal, broken rule). Write its heart in one sentence.
2. Design a twist table: setting / main object / rule / modern detail.
3. Draft a retelling of 12 to 18 sentences in your own words.
4. Highlight the twist in one colour and the kept heart in another.
5. Partner feedback: did the heart survive? If not, restore one key moment.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Write two endings for the same twist: one gentle, one sharper. Choose which suits a Year 2 audience and explain why in two sentences.

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **twist:** a planned change in a retelling
- **heart:** the core idea the tale protects
- **inspired by:** using a traditional pattern without copying a published text

## Along the way: our tale for a younger class

### ★ UNIT PROJECT

**Make:** a traditional-style tale retold for **Year 1 or Year 2** listeners.

*Must include:*

1. A clear hero, helper and trouble
2. A pattern a younger child can hear (repeat a line or three-part structure)
3. A gentle twist (new setting or object) with a kind heart
4. Own words throughout
5. A performance version (you may use a playscript layout if helpful)
6. A one-sentence introduction: "This is our retelling inspired by traditional tale patterns."

**Length:** about 200 to 300 words, or a 2-minute performance.

*Steps*

1. Plan roles and pattern on one page.
2. Draft.
3. Read to a partner of a similar age first; simplify hard words.
4. Practise performance: slow, clear, faces visible.
5. If possible, share with a younger class or record for your teacher.
6. After sharing, write three lines: what worked, what to change, what a younger listener said or showed.

*Success check*

- [ ] Younger listeners could follow the problem
- [ ] Pattern was audible
- [ ] Twist did not erase the heart
- [ ] Language was kind and clear

## What we learned • Unit 5

### ☑ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

1. I can explain how traditional tales travel.
2. I can name hero, helper and trouble.
3. I can use pattern and repetition on purpose.
4. I can retell with a twist while keeping the heart.
5. I have a tale ready for a younger audience.

### ■ UNIT 5 WORD ROUND-UP

traditional tale • retell • motif • hero • helper • trouble • pattern • repetition • build • twist • heart • inspired by

### → LOOKING AHEAD

Unit 6 leaves tale magic for **real writing**: reports, notes, paragraphs, letters and a report from your school week.



# Unit 6 • Reports and real writing

## Unit 6 • Reports and real writing

*Notes, paragraphs, letters and reports that tell the truth clearly*

### ⊙ IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- Explain what a report is for and who reads it.
- Take notes before you write full sentences.
- Build clear paragraphs with one main idea each.
- Write letters and messages that achieve a real purpose.
- Produce a report from your school week.

### UNIT 6 • TOPIC 6.1

## What a report is for

### ● SWITCH ON

Which text would you trust more if you needed the lunch menu tomorrow?

A. a funny story about soup B. a short report from the kitchen team with dates and choices

Why?

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

A **report** gives clear information about something that happened or something that is true now. Readers use reports to **find out**, not mainly to feel a story's tension.

Reports often answer:

- What happened?
- When and where?
- Who was involved?
- What was learned or decided?
- What happens next?

Tone is usually calm and fair. You may still write with energy, but you do not invent events. If you are unsure, you write *We do not know yet* rather than guessing.

“ EXTRACT · MINI-REPORT · 'LIBRARY UPDATE' ”

Library update · Week of 3 March 2026

On Monday 3 March, Year 4 returned 42 books and borrowed 37. The most popular shelf was Science. Two beanbags were moved nearer the window after pupils asked for better light. Next week the library will open at 08:20 on Tuesday for quiet reading.

Reported by the Library Helpers team.

■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Who is this report for, and what can a reader do with it?

1. Audience: pupils, teachers, families who use the library.
2. Uses: know borrowing numbers; know a change (beanbags); know next week's opening time.

**Check it a different way:** Write one sentence this report does **not** try to do (for example, it does not tell a fairy-tale plot).

#### ● YOUR TURN

1. List four questions a good school-week report might answer.
2. In the library extract, underline facts that include numbers or dates.
3. Rewrite the first sentence to include the school name (invent a realistic Portuguese school name if needed) without adding false events.
4. Sort these titles into Report / Story / Poem: \*The day the glue stuck everything\*, *Rain on the roof*, *Football club attendance*, *January*.
5. Write a three-sentence report about yesterday's break time using only things you truly know. If you lack a fact, leave a gap marked [?].

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Compare a news headline your teacher shares with a story opening. Make a Venn diagram: what they share, what only reports need, what only stories need.

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **report:** clear writing that informs about real events or facts
- **audience:** the people who will read the text
- **purpose:** the job the text is meant to do

#### UNIT 6 • TOPIC 6.2

### Notes before sentences

#### ● SWITCH ON

In 40 seconds, list everything you remember about your journey to school today. Do not write full sentences. Use arrows and short phrases only.

► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

**Notes** are thinking tools. They are allowed to be messy. Full sentences come later.

Helpful note habits:

- short phrases, not paragraphs
- abbreviations you will still understand tomorrow
- stars beside the most important points
- questions in the margin where a fact is missing
- sources jotted (*Ms Silva said, poster on door, I counted*)

Notes protect you from two problems: forgetting, and inventing. If it is not in the notes and you are not sure, check again before it enters the report.

“ EXTRACT · NOTES → SENTENCE

*Notes:*

- Mon 10 Mar
- science table
- 3 groups
- volcano models
- one model cracked / tape fix
- visitors: 2 parents 11:00

**Sentence built from notes:** On Monday 10 March, three groups showed volcano models on the science table; one model cracked and was repaired with tape before two parents visited at 11:00.

### ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

**Question:** Which note became which part of the sentence?

1. Date → *On Monday 10 March*
2. Numbers → *three groups, two parents, 11:00*
3. Problem/fix → *cracked / repaired with tape*

**Check it a different way:** Build a different sentence from the same notes that starts with the visitors.

### ● YOUR TURN

1. Turn these notes into two clear sentences:
  - Fri / football / pitch wet / moved to hall / 20 min / fair teams
2. Listen while a partner talks for thirty seconds about lunch. Take notes only. Read the notes back. Did you miss anything important?
3. For your classroom right now, make a note bank of eight facts you can see (no guessing).
4. Star the three notes that would matter most in a report for your headteacher.
5. Write one question mark note for something you cannot see but might need (*How many books were returned?*).

### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Create a personal note code (five abbreviations). Translate a partner's full sentence into your code, then back again. Check accuracy.

### ■ KEY WORDS

- **notes:** short recorded ideas used before formal writing
- **source:** where a fact came from
- **draft:** an early version you expect to improve

## Clear paragraphs

### ● SWITCH ON

Read two versions of a lunch report (your teacher can place them side by side). One is a single block. One has paragraphs. Which is easier to return to when you only need the dessert fact?

### ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

A **paragraph** is a group of sentences about **one main idea**.

In reports, paragraphs often follow a simple path:

1. **Topic sentence:** names the idea
2. **Detail sentences:** facts, numbers, examples
3. **Close** (optional): what it means or what happens next

Start a new paragraph when the idea changes: from *what happened* to *what we decided*, or from *morning* to *afternoon*.

Do not make every sentence its own paragraph. Do not glue unrelated facts into one mega-block.

### “ EXTRACT • PARAGRAPH • 'GARDEN CLUB' ”

Garden club met on Thursday at 15:10 behind the hall. Eight pupils planted chives in the herb trough and watered the pea seedlings. The water butt was half full after Wednesday's rain, so nobody needed the tap. Next week the club will weed the path before it becomes slippery.

#### ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

*Parts:*

1. Topic: garden club meeting time and place
2. Details: eight pupils, chives, peas, water butt
3. Next step: weed the path next week

**Check it a different way:** Split the paragraph into notes, then rebuild it in a different order without losing facts.

#### ● YOUR TURN

1. Underline the topic sentence in the garden paragraph.
2. Write a second paragraph about a problem the club might face (keep it realistic). Use at least three facts you invent carefully as a **scenario**, and label it *Scenario practice* so it is not confused with a real report.
3. Fix this muddle by splitting into two paragraphs:  
*Year 4 sang in assembly the fire drill was loud we lined up on the pitch the choir stood at the front rain began at the end.*
4. Partner edit: swap paragraphs and draw a box around any sentence that belongs elsewhere.
5. Write a three-paragraph mini-report on *Our classroom jobs this week* using only true facts.

#### → GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Take a page from your Unit 4 explanation. Re-chunk it into tighter paragraphs. Count sentences per paragraph and aim for a readable balance (not 1, not 12).

#### ■ KEY WORDS

- **paragraph:** a group of sentences about one main idea
- **topic sentence:** the sentence that names the paragraph's idea
- **unity:** when all sentences in a paragraph belong together

#### UNIT 6 • TOPIC 6.4

## Letters and messages that work

#### ● SWITCH ON

You need to cancel a club because of rain. Which message helps most?

A. "Hi stuff is off." B. "Hello, football club is cancelled today (12 March) because the pitch is flooded. Next session: Friday 14 March at 15:30. Thank you."

#### ► HERE IS HOW IT WORKS

**Letters** and **messages** are real writing with a job to do.

A working message usually includes:

- who it is to
- who it is from
- what the reader must know
- any date, time or place that matters
- what the reader should do next
- a polite close

School letters can be short. Clarity beats fancy words. Digital messages still need correct names and facts. If a message is public, ask a teacher before you send anything beyond classroom practice.

“ EXTRACT · LETTER · PERMISSION STYLE (MODEL FOR CRAFT, NOT A REAL FORM)

Dear Families,

Year 4 will visit the town library on Tuesday 18 March. We will leave school at 09:15 and return by 12:00. Pupils need a water bottle and a waterproof jacket. Please return the permission slip by Friday 14 March.

Thank you for your help.

Ms Rocha Year 4 teacher

#### ■ WATCH ME WORK ONE OUT

*Checklist against the letter:*

1. Audience: families
2. Event + date: library visit, Tuesday 18 March
3. Times: 09:15 to 12:00
4. What to bring: water bottle, waterproof jacket
5. Action needed: return slip by Friday 14 March
6. Sign-off: name and role

**Check it a different way:** Remove the action line. Notice how the letter becomes weaker.

#### ● YOUR TURN

1. Label each part of the model letter (greeting, facts, action, close).
2. Write a message to a classmate inviting them to a Writing Table lunchtime club. Include day, time, place and what to bring.
3. Rewrite this unclear message: "Tomorrow thing is later bring stuff." Make it usable.
4. Write a short thank-you letter to a visitor who read poems with your class. Keep a warm but clear tone.
5. Partner role-play: one reads as a busy parent; stop the writer each time a needed fact is missing.

→ GO A LITTLE FURTHER

Turn the library letter into three text-message length lines without losing safety facts. Then say what a formal letter can do that a tiny message cannot.

■ KEY WORDS

- **letter:** a written message with a greeting and sign-off
- **message:** a short communication with a clear purpose
- **sign-off:** the polite ending and name at the end

## Along the way: report from our school week

### ★ UNIT PROJECT

**Make:** a **School Week Report** for a real audience (class blog draft, corridor display, or letter home: your teacher chooses the real outlet).

#### *Must include:*

1. Title + date range of the week
2. Introduction paragraph (what this report covers)
3. At least two body paragraphs with true facts from notes
4. One paragraph on a highlight and one on a problem/solution (if any)
5. A short "Next week" section
6. Author line: your name or team name
7. Attached notes page (messy notes allowed) to show your process

#### *Process*

1. Take notes across two days minimum (or reconstruct carefully from known events with teacher help).
2. Star facts you can prove.
3. Build paragraphs from notes.
4. Edit for dates, numbers and names.
5. Peer check: a partner tries to find one missing fact a reader would want.
6. Fair copy.

#### *Success check*

- [ ] A reader learns at least five true facts
- [ ] Paragraphs have clear main ideas
- [ ] No invented events
- [ ] Next week section is useful
- [ ] Notes page shows the work behind the sentences

## What we learned • Unit 6

### ☑ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

1. I can explain what a report is for.
2. I can take notes before sentences.
3. I can write paragraphs with one main idea.
4. I can write letters and messages that work.
5. I have a school-week report ready to share.

### ■ UNIT 6 WORD ROUND-UP

report · audience · purpose · notes · source · draft · paragraph · topic sentence · unity · letter · message · sign-off

### → LOOKING BACK ACROSS THE BOOK

At The Writing Table you have practised story openings, voices on the page, poems, information craft, traditional retellings and real reports. Keep your best pages. Reread them. Notice how careful reading made clearer writing.

*Read carefully. Write clearly. Share the page.*

# Word list

## Glossary input - unit 1

> INPUT for the printed word list. Definitions for ages 8-9.

Line format: word - definition.

- character - who the story is about
- want - what the character hopes for or tries to do
- setting - where and when a story takes place
- problem - the trouble that makes the story move
- opening - the first lines of a story
- hook - a detail or question that makes a reader want more
- precise detail - a clear, specific fact such as a time, object or place
- senses - sight, hearing, smell, touch and taste used to build a scene
- atmosphere - the feeling a setting creates
- plan - notes that map a piece of writing before full sentences
- problem seed - the first trouble, not the whole ending
- draft - an early version of writing you expect to improve
- fair copy - a neat final version of a piece of writing

## Glossary input - unit 2

Line format: word - definition.

- narrative - the storyteller's voice telling what happens
- dialogue - the words characters say
- speech marks - the marks that wrap spoken words
- speech tag - words such as said or asked that show who spoke
- new line rule - start a new line when the speaker changes
- motivation - what a character wants and why
- show, not label - use speech and action instead of only naming a feeling

- playscript - text written for performance
- stage direction - an instruction for action, not spoken aloud

## Glossary input - unit 3

Line format: word - definition.

- poem - writing that uses sound, line and image with special care
- line - a row of words in a poem; it may be shorter than a sentence
- rhyme - words that share end sounds (optional in poems)
- rhythm - the beat and pace of a line
- alliteration - repeated starting sounds in nearby words
- onomatopoeia - words that sound like their meaning
- line break - the place where a line of poetry ends
- image - a clear word-picture in the reader's mind
- simile - a comparison using like or as
- metaphor - a comparison that says one thing is another
- list poem - a poem built from a patterned list
- shape poem - a poem whose layout suggests its subject
- pattern - a repeating structure a reader can follow

## Glossary input - unit 4

Line format: word - definition.

- information text - writing that explains or informs rather than tells a story
- scan - look quickly for a key word or answer
- evidence - words in the text that support an answer
- heading - a section title that names the topic
- caption - an explanation under a picture
- label - a short name attached to part of a diagram
- fact - something that can be checked and shown to be true
- opinion - a belief or feeling that can differ between people
- paraphrase - say the same meaning in different words

- explanation - writing that shows how or why something works
- sequence - the order of steps
- precise verb - a verb that names the exact action

## Glossary input - unit 5

Line format: word - definition.

- traditional tale - a story passed through a community over time
- retell - tell again in your own words
- motif - a repeated story ingredient such as a rule, a test or a helper
- hero - the main character who faces the central problem
- helper - a character or force that supports the hero
- trouble - the obstacle, threat or problem driving the tale
- pattern - a repeating structure in a story
- repetition - words or events that return on purpose
- build - how each repeat grows stronger or changes
- twist - a planned change in a retelling
- heart - the core idea the tale protects
- inspired by - using a traditional pattern without copying a published text

## Glossary input - unit 6

Line format: word - definition.

- report - clear writing that informs about real events or facts
- audience - the people who will read the text
- purpose - the job the text is meant to do
- notes - short recorded ideas used before formal writing
- source - where a fact came from
- draft - an early version you expect to improve
- paragraph - a group of sentences about one main idea
- topic sentence - the sentence that names the paragraph's idea
- unity - when all sentences in a paragraph belong together

- letter - a written message with a greeting and sign-off
- message - a short communication with a clear purpose
- sign-off - the polite ending and name at the end of a letter

# Source log - whole book inputs

> Every factual claim meant for print should be checkable. Model stories, poems > and classroom scenarios in this title are original Prime fiction or classroom > craft unless noted.

Background facts used in information models:

Line format: claim - source - url or reference - date checked.

- Cork oaks grow in Portugal and the western Mediterranean; bark can be harvested without felling the tree; cork used for stoppers, floors, boards - general botanical and industry knowledge widely documented by national cork associations and school geography texts - verify with teacher atlas / APCOR educational materials if citing numbers in class - 2026-08-06
- Portugal is a leading cork producer - widely reported industry fact; for pupil text kept qualitative ("one of the world's leading") rather than a fragile percentage - 2026-08-06
- Lisbon trams climb steep routes and share roads with cars - observable city transport fact; no passenger statistics claimed in the pupil extract - 2026-08-06
- School library, garden and club models - original classroom scenarios, not claims about a named real school - n/a - 2026-08-06
- All narrative extracts (Ina, Tiago, night market, lighthouse-style scenes, playscripts, poems, folk-style mini-tales) - original Prime School writing for this edition - internal - 2026-08-06
- Traditional tale unit uses original motifs and Prime retellings; not a transcription of any single publisher's text - internal craft decision - 2026-08-06
- PDF/Input English Y04 Student Book.pdf - third-party image scan used for skills scope only; no continuous prose reused - local Input folder - 2026-08-06
- Cover art FRONT\_BOOK\_COVER.png / BACK\_BOOK\_COVER.png - Prime Books cover files on disk - BOOK COVER/ - 2026-08-06
- Design palette hex values - sampled from FRONT\_BOOK\_COVER.png with PIL - 01-DESIGN.md - 2026-08-06

# Back matter - English Year 4

> Word list, sources, for teachers, back-cover copy. > Printed glossary and sources sections should be generated from 04- and 05- > inputs at build time so they cannot drift from the body.

## Word list

Generate from 04-GLOSSARY-01 through 04-GLOSSARY-06 , A to Z, with unit numbers. Pupil-facing definitions only.

## Sources and references

Generate from 05-SOURCES-01.md . Keep original fiction extracts labelled as Prime School original writing. Keep factual background lines separate from classroom scenarios.

## Answers

This title uses open talk, drafting and performance. There is no separate answer key for closed numerical items. Teachers judge using the success checks in each unit project and the "What we learned" lists.

## For teachers

### Pathway and age

- Subject: English
- Year: 4 · ages 8-9 · Lower Primary
- Identity: **The Writing Table**
- Spine: Read carefully. Write clearly. Share the page.
- Page budget guideline: 110-120 pages (DEC-034)
- Status: in\_development until a PM removes the slug from readiness.json

### How the book is organised

Six units balance reading, writing, speaking and listening:

1. Story openings
2. Characters who speak
3. Poems and word music
4. Finding things out
5. Traditional tales
6. Reports and real writing

Each unit follows BOOK-ANATOMY furniture: switch on, short teaching, worked example, practice, stretch, keywords, unit project, self-check.

### Scheme and input

- Authority plan: 06-SCHEME-MAP.md
- PDF/Input holds a third-party image scan for **skills scope only**
- All continuous teaching prose and model texts are original Prime writing
- Do not paste publisher body text into lessons

### Classroom notes

- British English throughout
- Portuguese names and places appear as setting flavour
- Performance and partner talk are part of assessment evidence
- Unit 5 retellings must stay kind and age-safe for younger audiences
- Unit 6 reports must use true classroom facts; label scenarios when invented

for practice only

### Cover note

Front cover art currently shows older template wording ("Cambridge Early Years / Student Manual"). Body text uses Student Book, ages 8-9. Plan a cover type pass later; do not invent a second cover file set without the cover pipeline.

### Build note

This title is MARKDOWN-authored. WORKSTATION/\_build is not yet scaffolded. Shipping a PDF requires engine work plus gates; readiness remains PM-owned.

## **Back cover copy**

*The Writing Table*

English · Year 4 · Student Book

Read carefully. Write clearly. Share the page.

From first lines that hook a reader to reports from a real school week, this book builds the craft of English: stories, voices, poems, information, traditional tales and practical writing.

Prime Books · Prime School · [www.primeschool.pt](http://www.primeschool.pt)

# Read like a writer. Write like a reader.

---

This Year 4 Student Book takes stories apart to show how they work, then helps you build your own. You will study an original extract, learn about narrative and dialogue, and write an opening with real dialogue in it.

Written for Prime School pupils, in clear British English, with original stories written for this book.

STORIES

DIALOGUE

DESCRIPTION

WRITING

READING

